

LOVERS

Shakespeare's love stories are full of passion and tragedy and have aged well.

ANTONY AND CLEOPATRA

Marc Antony, one of the three rulers of the Roman Empire, neglects his political duties to spend time with the beautiful queen of Egypt, Cleopatra. When he returns to Rome he is persuaded to marry Caesar's sister, Octavia, which sends Cleopatra into a jealous rage. Caesar and Antony end up at war with each other, and Antony, aided by Cleopatra, loses. In the ensuing betrayal and treachery, both lovers commit suicide. (*Antony and Cleopatra*)

ROMEO AND JULIET

Two teenagers from warring families in Verona must disguise their love for one another. They marry in secret, and Juliet fakes her own death to escape her family's plans to marry her off to another man. In a misunderstanding, however, Romeo believes his wife to be truly dead and kills himself. When Juliet discovers his body she, too, commits suicide. These "star-crossed lovers" are perhaps Shakespeare's most well-known romantic duo, and their story still has great appeal today. (*Romeo and Juliet*)



TROILUS AND CRESSIDA

During the Trojan war, the young prince Troilus falls in love with Cressida. They spend one night together and Cressida swears her love. However, she is then sent to the enemy camp where her father has defected. Here Troilus watches as she accepts the wooing of Diomedes. This is Shakespeare's darkest and most cynical play. (*Troilus and Cressida*)

Sculpture of lovers in Central Park, New York

VILLAINS



The three witches weave a spell to cause the downfall of Macbeth.

Shakespeare's most exciting characters are his villains, whose wickedness is often what drives the plots.

AARON

The servant to and lover of the Queen of the Goths orders the brutal rape of Titus Andronicus's daughter, Lavinia. He is buried to the neck in sand and starved. (*Titus Andronicus*)

EDMUND

Edmund plots to destroy his trusting brother and father in order to become Duke of Gloucester. (*King Lear*)

IAGO

Wicked Iago delights in deceiving Othello into believing that his wife is unfaithful. Iago never gives a real reason for hating Othello, although being passed over for promotion may be one. (*Othello*)

RICHARD III

A ruthlessly ambitious duke who orders the murder of his brother and two innocent nephews in order to become king. He is eventually killed in battle. (*Richard III*)

SHYLOCK

Not a clear-cut villain because he is also a victim. However, his demand that Antonio give him a pound of flesh for an unpaid debt is morally evil. (*The Merchant of Venice*)

THREE WITCHES

Three "black and midnight hags" plot evil against Macbeth using prophecies and spells. They are servants of the goddess of the underworld, Hecate. (*Macbeth*)

FOOLS

These comic characters not only provide laughter, but often words of wisdom as well.

BOTTOM

Bottom the weaver ends up with the head of an ass after a practical joke from the fairy folk. (*A Midsummer Night's Dream*)

DOGBERRY

The ridiculous constable in charge of the night watch misuses words to comic effect. (*Much Ado About Nothing*)

FALSTAFF

This larger-than-life character appears in several plays. He is a pleasure-loving coward with no sense of right or wrong, but is very entertaining. (*Henry IV, parts 1 and 2*; *The Merry Wives of Windsor*)

FESTE

A professional fool, or court jester, who makes his living by making others laugh. (*Twelfth Night*)

FOOL

Simply known as Fool, this court jester is a wise fool who often tells King Lear uncomfortable truths. (*King Lear*)

NURSE

Juliet's companion is a chatty fool who often talks nonsense but who is also a very important and likable character. (*Romeo and Juliet*)

TOUCHSTONE

The court fool who utters cynical truths. (*As You Like It*)



A court jester wore a cap and bells.